A Question of Belonging

In April 1968, Ratan was transferred to TISCO's headquarters in Bombay and appointed as executive officer in the office of its vice chairman. Among his remit were long-term planning, techno-economic evaluation of all new projects, establishment of control systems, new project development, and research and development projects. In November of the following year, when he had barely begun to settle down in his new job, he was posted to Australia.

The newest posting was as Tata's resident representative in the country and its neighbours to identify and generate new business opportunities for the Tata Group. He was also specifically required to be associated with the formation of a joint venture (JV) company between Tata International AG and Dalgety Australia Limited. It led to the setting up of a new company called Dalgety Tata Pvt. Ltd. But again, within eight months of his reaching the Australian shores, Ratan was called back to India in August 1970.

On his return, he was appointed to Tata Consultancy Services (TCS). This was at the behest of P.M. Agerwala, managing director (MD) of Tata Electric Companies and director-in-charge of TCS. At the software company, there was nothing specific that Ratan was assigned to do. As he recalls, he was 'pushing papers for Mr Agerwala, to get something going'. But it gave him a ringside view of the functioning of a software company whose importance was still undiscovered in India and the challenges it faced.

The constant shifting of jobs was unsettling for Ratan. It appeared as if he was being moved around as nobody had a concrete plan for him. Many Tata veterans, however, viewed the several postings as deliberate steps taken to groom Ratan for a larger role in the group. Some believed that this was JRD's intent too. But as events unfolded, there was little to support such a conclusion.

On 26 March 1971, Ratan was appointed as a director in the National Radio & Electronics Company Limited (NELCO). The company primarily